American Dream / American Nightmare Conference

July 3rd-4th 2025

UNIVERSITY OF WESTMINSTER

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Thanks to our Funders!

The conference team would like to extend a huge thank you to our funders: the British Association for American Studies (BAAS), the Centre for Indigenous and Settler Colonial Studies Centre (CISCS), and the School of Humanities Research Committee at the University of Westminster.

Organising Team Welcome and Information

We are thrilled to welcome you to the inaugural American Dream / American Nightmare conference where we will consider the fantastical and the horrific in the American context, exploring the best and the worst of life and experiences in North America/Turtle Island across various fields.

We are proud to present a range of panels, roundtables, and posters which host the research and ideas of a range of graduate, early-career, and established researchers and writers. We have no doubt that the knowledge and experiences shared at the conference will incite interesting and plentiful discussion, and we encourage presenters and attendees alike to network during the designated networking sessions and breaks the schedule provides, and after the conference ends.

This year's conference is being hosted by the New Voices in Postcolonial Studies Network (NVPoco) in collaboration with the University of Westminster who are kindly providing the physical space for the in-person day of the event. NVPoco is a collaborative, multi-disciplinary network for those interested in Postcolonial Studies. If you would like to hear more about the work we do, please contact us at newvoicespocostudies@gmail.com, or speak to the current directors of the network during the conference.

The conference was conceived by this years' NVPoco Network directors, Soph and Juni, to produce more American Studies aligned work within the NVPoco Network, and the theme was decided upon in the run up to the U.S. presidential election in 2024. The theme hopes to encourage important dialogue on the broad range of experiences and cultural production coming from Turtle Island/North America, especially in the current political, economic, and social climate.

The entire conference team looks forward to meeting you, both online and in-person very soon!

What Can We Do in the Current Context?

While academic research has many concrete implications, the organisers of the conference team wanted to ensure that, in hosting this event, the support we are collectively offering to people in the U.S. exceeds the bounds of theory. For this reason, we have compiled a short list of a few organisations that are working hard to counter the harms carried out by the current administration. Our ambitions for this list are to encourage concrete support for the contexts and communities explored in research, whether that support is monetary or other, for those who wish to do so. Furthermore, while conversations critiquing the harms experienced by communities across the United States are important, we also wish to draw focus back to discussions of resilience, agency, and hope.

This list is not by any means exhaustive[1], and we wholeheartedly encourage everyone to continue doing their own research into current events as they continue to unfold across a wide span of geographical contexts.

NDN Girls Book Club

"NDN Girls Book Club is a 501(c)3 literary organization run by and for Indigenous peoples that hosts free youth workshops, hosts author talks, uplifts Indigenous literature, supports Indigenous booksellers, and sends out free Native books.

In 2023, we distributed more than 2,000 books by Indigenous authors. In 2024, we embarked on an epic journey across the Navajo and Hopi Nations to distribute 10,000 free Native books. We've travelled from Muckleshoot in Washington to Piscataway lands in the Northeast, leading workshops in classrooms, tribal libraries, tribal colleges, book festivals, and museums."
https://ndngirlsbookclub.org/

The Trevor Project

"The Trevor Project is the leading suicide prevention and crisis intervention nonprofit organization for LGBTQ+ young people. We provide information & support to LGBTQ+ young people 24/7, all year round."

https://www.thetrevorproject.org/

[1] Please note that, given the scope of this conference, we have only included organisations working in and around the North American context. However, that does not negate or temper the importance of other causes

The Immigrant Defense Project

“The Immigrant Defense Project (IDP) was founded over 20 years ago to combat an emerging human rights crisis: the targeting of immigrants for mass imprisonment and deportation.

As this crisis has continued to escalate, IDP has remained steadfast in fighting for fairness and justice for immigrants caught at the intersection of the racially biased U.S. criminal justice systems. IDP fights to end the current era of unprecedented mass criminalization, detention, and deportation through a multipronged strategy including advocacy, litigation, legal advice and training, community defense, grassroots alliances, and strategic communications.”

https://www.immigrantdefenseproject.org/about/

Women’s Reproductive Rights Assistance Project

“WRRAP assists women (*WRRAP’s definition of “women” includes transgender, genderqueer and non-binary people who are woman-identified)* and girls of all ethnicities, sexual orientations, gender identities, and cultural backgrounds who are financially unable to pay for safe, legal abortions or emergency contraceptives. We provide funds directly to pre-screened, pre-qualified health clinics and doctors across the nation on behalf of women in need of abortion services or emergency contraceptives. WRRAP does not ask for repayment of funds.”

https://wrrap.org/

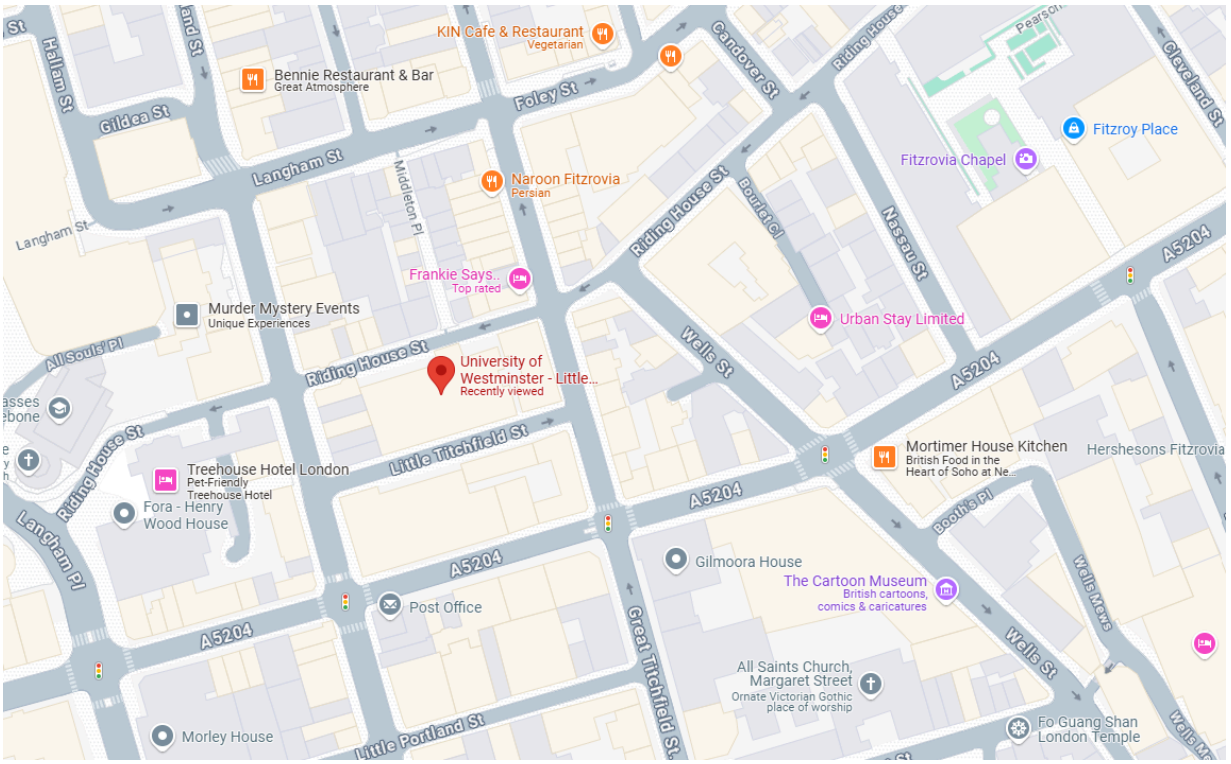
Meet the Organising Team

The organising team will be available across both days of the conference. Below are our names, pronouns, email addresses, and faces for you to familiarise yourselves with.

	Soph Harris-Nijmeijer They/Them s.harris2@westminster.ac.uk
	Juni Kvarving She/Her jk616@kent.ac.uk
	Francesca Quinn She/Her ftr511@york.ac.uk

	Sophia Arnold She/Her sea38@kent.ac.uk
	Max Shirley He/Him m.shirley@westminster.ac.uk

Location



On Thursday 3rd July, the conference will be held **online via Zoom**. The Zoom link is as follows: https://york-ac-uk.zoom.us/j/93169697678?pwd=aDztTZTS8aabKD0BQYdB6J9yD4CX3k.1

On Friday 4th July, the conference will be hosted at the University of Westminster's venue, Portland Hall. The venue's address is: **4–12 Little Titchfield St, London, W1W 7BY**

The closest tube station is Oxford Circus, which can be accessed on the Victoria Line.

The venue is also 10-minutes walk from Goodge Street Station (Northern Line), Great Portland Street Station (Hammersmith, Circle and Metropolitan Lines), and Bond Street Station (Elizabeth Line and Jubilee Line).

Accessibility

The University of Westminster has produced an accessibility guide for the Little Titchfield St Campus, which can be found here. Please consult the guide for detailed information.

There is an accessible entrance to the rear of the building, including a ramp/slope. The main entrance is equipped with a lift. Lifts are available throughout the building for public use and the basement level (Portland Hall) can be accessed via the lifts. Accessible toilets are available on both the ground floor and first floor.

To aid in the conference's accessibility, before beginning any presentation we encourage speakers to give a short description of their appearance for those who would benefit from this. For example,"I am Soph, use they/them pronouns and am a mid-20's white person with short ginger hair and I am wearing black trousers and an orange t-shirt".

Nearby lunch options

Thanks to the University of Westminster's School of Humanities Research Committee, there will be pastries, tea, and coffee provided on arrival on Friday 4th July, and light refreshments in the late afternoon.

You are welcome to bring your own food but, should you wish to purchase lunch, the venue is located near a variety of cafes and restaurants, some of the closest of which are listed below:

- Kaffeine - 66 Great Titchfield St, London, W1W 7QJ
- Mortimers Cafe - 26 Mortimer St, London, W1W 7RB
- ScandiKitchen Cafe & Shop - 61 Great Titchfield St, London, W1W 7PP
- Pret A Manger - Network House, 5-11 Mortimer St, London, W1T 3JB; 298 Regent St, London W1B 3AP; 31 Cavendish Square, London, W1G 0PW
- The Gallery Coffee Shop - 309 Regent St, London, W1B 2HW
- Little Portland cafe - 15 Little portland St, London, W1W 8BW

Conference Dinner/Drinks

On the in-person conference day (4th July), we would love to facilitate conference attendees/speakers getting some dinner and/or drinks together after the program for the day is finished. If you would like to join, please fill out the following google form by the 3rd July and we will make sure you are included in the table-booking for a nearby restaurant/pub:

https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSe8EqtK60e7xqwCM74nWjd02lMZ89lMaTUa13JqHvpkqHZ-zw/viewform?usp=header

See you there!

Code of Conduct

We are very excited to see all of you in-person and online for the conference. To ensure the best experience possible for our attendees, we would like to remind everyone of the values necessary for an inclusive, respectful, and supportive environment.

During the conference, we will not tolerate racism, sexism, ableism, homophobia, transphobia, classism, xenophobia, sizeism, or any other form of prejudice. The identities of others are to be respected. We will not tolerate any depictions, discussions, or behaviours that undermine the dignity and respect of any person, and any person reported as doing so will be asked to leave immediately.

Beyond this, to ensure respectful communication, we ask that all attendees use the names and pronouns that others have specified. If you are unsure of someone's pronouns, we suggest that you ask, or use "they" as a placeholder. You may also refer back to this booklet for presenter information as the names and pronouns of all speaker's can be found in the 'Further Speaker and Presentation Information' section below.

If, during the conference, you experience any form of harassment, discrimination, or bullying (which we define in-line with the British Association for American Studies' definitions), you can report it to one of the organising team, either by emailing the general inbox which will be checked regularly throughout the conference (americandreamamericannightmare@gmail.com), or by emailing one of the organisers individually (emails can be found above besides their respective profiles).

All organisers will be present on the in-person day, so please do find and speak to us if an issue should arise, or if we can do anything to improve your experience.

We take these matters seriously and any issues will be addressed immediately to ensure an inclusive and as safe a space as possible for all participants.

Please also find a list of contacts below in case of a physical emergency or if additional support is required:

- Emergency services: 999
- Non-urgent medical services: 111
- Mind support line: 0300 102 1234
- Samaritans: 116 123
- Text 'Shout' on 85258 for 24/7 text crisis helpline

Conference Programme

*The conference will follow the BST timezone.

Thursday 3rd July - Online

Time	Event	Confirmed Speaker(s)	Chair
9.30AM	Arrival and Welcome from Organisers	Soph Harris-Nijmeijer (University of Westminster)	
9.45AM	**Keynote Speech** Capitalising on the Past: Heritage, Industry, and the Environmental Racism in the American Gulf States	Dr. Lucy Bond (University of Westminster)	Max Shirley (University of Westminster)

10.45AM	**Roundtable 1** Poetics of Resistance	- Dr. Kate Lewis Hood (Queen Mary University of London) - Dr. Rona Cran (University of Birmingham) - Dr. Swati Rana (University of California, Santa Barbara)	Simar Bhasin (Shiv Nadar Institution of Eminence (Delhi-NCR))
12PM	Lunch		
1PM	**Parallel Panels 1-3**		
	The Dystopia	- Eptisum Laskar - Jacob Moose - Yifei Jing - Brittney Finley	Lena Elipe-Gutiérrez (University of Oviedo)
	The American Dream/Nightmare on Film	- Nick Berbiers - Upasana Sarangi - Tweed	Jack Dice (University of Kent)
	The Body	- Carla Abella Rodriquez - Anouk Herman	Julia Szoltysek (University of Silesia)

2.15PM	**Roundtable 2** Perspectives within New and Emerging Media	- Prof. John Wills (University of Kent) - Dr. Sara A. Polak (Leiden University) - Dr. Stephen Morgan (King's College London)	Howard Lukk (University of Westminster)
3.30PM	Break		
3.45PM	**Roundtable 3** Indigenous Horror on Turtle Island	- Dr. Krista Collier-Jarvis (Mount Saint Vincent University) - Tiffany Morris	Mariana Chajon Oliveros (University of Western Ontario)
5PM	**Panel 4** In Conversation with Author Curtis Chin: *Everything I Learned, I Learned in a Chinese Restaurant*	Curtis Chin	Francesca Quinn (University of York)
5.45PM	Closing notes	Juni Kvarving (University of Kent)	
6PM	End of day		

Friday 4th July - Little Titchfield Street, University of Westminster

Time	Event	Confirmed Speaker(s)	Chair
9AM	Arrival and welcome from organisers	Soph Harris-Nijmeijer (University of Westminster)	
9.45AM	**Roundtable 1** Along State Lines: Nation and Nationalism, Borders, and Changing Territories /Landscapes	- Dr. Shelley Angelie Saggar (Goldsmiths University) - Dr. Ananya Mishra (Queen Mary University of London) - Fatma Tabassum (Rama Devi Women's University)	Catarina Moura (Universidade Nova de Lisboa)
11AM	Break		
11.30AM	**Roundtable 2** The American Gothic, Weird Fiction, and Bodily Horror	- Dr. Jimmy Packham (University of Birmingham) - Dr. Jade Jenkinson (University of Nottingham) - Dr. Juha Virtanen (University of Kent)	Lolly Sillitoe (University of Westminster)
12.45PM	Lunch and Poster Presentations	- Catarina Moura - Eleni Ermioni Tasioula - Lolly Sillitoe - Evripidis Karavasilis	
1.45PM	**Panel 1** Two-Spirit, Trans, and Drag Potentialities in the North American Context	- Albert McLeod - Lea Pešec - Izzy Hardin	Evripidis Karavasilis (Universitat de Barcelona)

3PM	Break		
3.30PM	**Keynote Panel** Speaking to the 'American Dream / American Nightmare' in 2025	- Dr. Elsa Devienne (Northumbria University) - Dr. Jonathan Ward (King's College London) - Dr. Christopher Lloyd (University of Hertfordshire) - Dr. Michael (Mike) Collins (King's College London)	Soph Harris-Nijmeijer (University of Westminster)
5PM	**Poster Presentations and Networking**	- Catarina Moura - Eleni Ermioni Tasioula - Lolly Sillitoe - Evripidis Karavasilis	
5.45PM	Closing notes and conference end	Juni Kvarving (University of Kent)	
6PM onwards	Drinks and/or dinner (location TBD)		

Further Speaker and Presentation Information

Thursday 3rd July

Keynote Speech - Capitalising on the Past: Heritage, Industry, and the Environmental Racism in the American Gulf States

The conference begins with our inaugural keynote speech given by **Dr. Lucy Bond** (she/her). Lucy is Head of the School of Humanities and Reader in Literature and Memory Studies at the University of Westminster. She has published widely on the culture and politics of memory and trauma. Her work includes: *Frames of Memory After 9/11: Culture, Criticism, Politics and Law* (Palgrave, 2015), and the *New Critical Idiom* guide to *Trauma* (Routledge, 2020, co-authored with Stef Craps). Lucy has also published a number of edited collections, including: *The Transcultural Turn: Interrogating Memory Between and Beyond Borders* (de Gruyter, 2014); *Memory Unbound: Tracing the Dynamics of Memory Studies* (Berghahn, 2016); and *Planetary Memory in Contemporary American Fiction* (Routledge, 2018).

Roundtable 1 - Poetics of Resistance

This roundtable features Dr. Rona Cran (they/them), Dr. Kate Lewis Hood (they/she), and Dr. Swati Rana (she/her).

Rona Cran is a London-based writer and scholar. Their first poetry collection, *I Remember Kim*, was published with Verve Poetry Press in 2023. They are the author of *Collage in Twentieth-Century Art, Literature, and Culture* (2014) and the editor of *Conversations with New York School Poets* (2025). Forthcoming books include *Multiple Voices: New York City Poetry from the Mimeograph Revolution to the HIV/AIDS Pandemic* and *Shadows and Benedictions: a personal history of sharks.* They are Associate Professor of Twentieth-Century American Literature at the University of Birmingham, and the founding co-director of the Network for New York School Studies.

Kate Lewis Hood is an interdisciplinary scholar and writer, and a Lecturer in English at Queen Mary University of London. Kate's current book project, *Overlapping Currents*, considers how Black and Indigenous poetics address

the durational and nonlinear effects of colonialism, racial capitalism, and heteropatriarchy in watery places in Turtle Island/North America and the Pacific islands. Kate's work attends to relationships between poetry and place-based practices of water protection, performance, and decolonial infrastructure-making, and seeks to be in conversation to build responsible anti-colonial, queer and feminist methodologies from the UK. You can find Kate on Instagram: @coneffluents

Swati Rana is a poet and professor. She is the author of *Race Characters*, which explores how social personhood and literary persona intersect. Her creative writing has appeared in *Asian American Literary Review*, *The Brooklyn Rail*, *The Dalhousie Review*, *Granta*, *The Immanent Frame*, *Jacket2*, *Michigan Quarterly Review*, *The Paris Review*, *swamp pink*, *Wasafiri*, and elsewhere. Her literary criticism has appeared in *Amerasia Journal, American Literature*, *American Literary History*, the *Journal of Asian American Studies*, and *The Cambridge Companion to Race and American Literature*. In 2023, she received the Queen Mary *Wasafiri* New Writing Prize in Poetry. She teaches in the Department of English at University of California, Santa Barbara as Associate Professor. Find her at www.swatirana.com.

Parallel Panels -

The Dystopia panel features three presentations.

The first presentation is ‘Dreaming Beyond Dystopia: Indigenous Futurism and Resistance in Cherie Dimaline’s *The Marrow Thieves*’ by **Eptisum Laskar** (she/her).

The second is ‘A Reimagined Light: Nature, Post-Human Urbanism, and the Subversion of the American Dream in Jeff VanderMeer's Southern Reach Series’ by **Jacob Moos**e (he/him).

The third presentation will be given by **Yifei Jing** (he/him) and is titled ‘Centering the Border: Place, Motion, and Indigeneity in Gerald Vizenor’s *Treaty Shirts*’.

The final presentation for this panel is by **Brittney Finley** (she/they) and is titled ‘Ecological Eschatology: *Fallout* of the American Dream’.

The American Dream/Nightmare on Film panel consists of three presentations.

The first presentation is titled 'From Kennedy's Moon to Fallen Liberty: American Dreams and Nightmares Reflected in the Original *Planet of the Apes* Films (1968-1973)' and will be given by **Nick Berbiers** (he/him).
The second will be given by **Upasana Sarangi** (she/her) and is titled 'The Horrors of What Could Have Been: The Spectral American Dream in *Past Lives*'.

The final presentation for this panel is titled 'Turtle Island Tales' and will be given by **Tweed** (please refer to Tweed by name only).

The Body panel consists of 2 presentations

Carla Abella Rodriquez's (she/her) presentation is titled 'The Black Body in Contemporary African American Fiction: A Dissection of Spectacular Violence in Nana Kwame Adjei-Brenyah's *Friday Black* (2018)'.

Anouk Herman's (she/they) presentation is titled 'The MFA Nightmare: Mona Awad's *Bunny* (2019) and the Subversion of Campus Fiction'.

Roundtable 2 - Perspectives within 'New' and 'Emerging' Media

This roundtable features Professor John Wills (he/him), Dr. Sara Polak (she/her), and Dr. Stephen Morgan (he/him).

John Wills is a Professor in Film and Media at the University of Kent, UK and a co-editor of the European Journal of American Culture (Intellect). His research interests include atomic film and culture, environmental protest and environmental disaster, and US game studies. John is the author of seven books, including, most recently, *Gamer Nation: Video Games and American Culture* (Johns Hopkins UP, 2019) and with Esther Wright, *Red Dead Redemption: History, Myth and Violence in the Video Game West* (Oklahoma UP, 2023). He is currently completing a new book, on Doom Town and atomic culture, with the University Press of Kansas.

Sara Polak is a university lecturer in American Studies at Leiden University Centre for the Arts in Society, research fellow on the NWO project Playing Politics: Media Platforms Making Worlds, and PI of the ERC project Worlding

America: How Play Shaped the United States from New Media to Politics, 1503-2028. She has published a monograph *FDR in American Memory* (John Hopkins UP, 2021) and is working on a book about *How Trump Plays.*

Stephen Morgan is Lecturer in Film Studies at King's College London. His research focuses on the cinemas of settler nations, as well as the Indigenous cinemas of Australia, Canada, and Aotearoa / New Zealand. Broader efforts to reconceptualise settler national cinema in these spaces includes his upcoming monograph, *Ealing Abroad: Post-War British Cinema, Settler Colonialism and Ealing Studios in Australia*, which will be published by BFI/Bloomsbury in 2026.

Roundtable 3 - Indigenous Horror on Turtle Island

This roundtable features Dr. Krista Collier-Jarvis (nekm/she/her) and Tiffany Morris (she/her).

Krista Collier-Jarvis is a member of the Mi'kmaw First Nation and an Assistant Professor in the Department of English at Mount Saint Vincent University. She teaches American and Indigenous literatures, climate fiction, and film. She has published several articles and book chapters, including uncanny play in *Pet Sematary*, haunting back in *Blood Quantum*, endemicity in *The Last of Us*, and the rise of the rhizombie. She recently completed a two-week horror writing residency at the Banff Centre for Arts and Creativity under the mentorship of Shane Hawk where she worked on Indigenous horror. Krista is the co-lead on the Two-Eyed Seeing project and is the Early Career Representative for the Indigenous Literary Studies Association.

Tiffany Morris is an L'nu'skw (Mi'kmaw) writer from Nova Scotia. She is the author of the ecohorror novella Green Fuse Burning and the Elgin Award-winning horror poetry collection Elegies of Rotting Stars. Her work has appeared in the Indigenous horror anthology Never Whistle At Night, as well as in Nightmare Magazine, Uncanny Magazine, and Apex Magazine, among others. Her MA thesis, "The Apocalypse Will Not Be Colonized: Crisis, Monsters, and Futurism in Recent Indigenous Narratives" won the Acadia University Outstanding Masters Research Award in 2022.

Panel 4 - In Conversation with Author Curtis Chin: *Everything I Learned, I Learned in a Chinese Restaurant*

This panel will feature a discussion between author Curtis Chin, panel chair and conference co-organiser Francesca Quinn, and the audience.

Curtis Chin is co-founder of the Asian American Writers' Workshop in New York City, and he served as the non-profits' first Executive Director. He went on to write comedy for network and cable television before transitioning to social justice documentaries. Chin has screened his films at over 600 venues in twenty countries. He has written for CNN, Bon Appetit, the Detroit Free Press, and the Emancipator/Boston Globe. A graduate of the University of Michigan, Chin has received awards from ABC/Disney Television, New York Foundation for the Arts, National Endowment for the Arts, and more. His memoir, *Everything I Learned, I Learned in a Chinese Restaurant* was published by Little, Brown in Fall 2023. His essay in Bon Appetit was selected for Best Food Writing in America 2023.

Friday 4th July

Roundtable 1 - Along State Lines: Nation and Nationalism, Borders, and Changing Territories/Landscapes

This roundtable consists of Dr. Shelley Angelie Saggar (they/she), Dr. Ananya Mishra (she/her), and Fatma Tabassum (she/her).

Shelley Angelie Saggar is a postdoctoral researcher in the Department of English and Creative Writing at Goldsmiths, University of London. They are researching Choctaw and Irish (hi)stories of culinary migration and sustenance as part of the AHRC-funded 'Sharing Lands: Reconciliation, Recognition & Reciprocity' project. Their research examines the intersections between Indigenous literary studies and museum practice, taking an interdisciplinary approach with the aim of bridging these fields. Shelley's wider research interests include Fourth Cinema, environmental heritage and museum studies. Their work has been published in the *Journal of Postcolonial Writing,* the *Journal of Museum Ethnography* and *ART HX.*

Ananya Mishra is a Lecturer in Global Race Studies at the Department of English in School of the Arts, Queen Mary University of London. She is currently working on her monograph *Evidentiary Literatures: Refusal and Resurgence in Global Indigenous Texts*. Her recent publications include a reflective paper titled "'Jami Chadiba Nahin: We Will Not Leave this Land': Materiality and Imagination in Indigenous Land Ethics" in British Association of

American Studies (BAAS) special issue in New Area Studies, Vol. 4.3 (2024), and a co-written chapter titled “Common Worlds and Common Words in Lionel Fogarty’s India Poems” in *Lionel Fogarty’s Poetry and Politics* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2025).

Fatma Tabassum is originally from Cuttack, Odisha. I completed my B.Sc. in Zoology from Rama Devi Women’s University, Bhubaneswar, and subsequently earned an M.A. in English Literature from Indira Gandhi National Open University, New Delhi. After qualifying for the UGC NET-JRF, she joined the Department of English at Rama Devi Women’s University as a Ph.D. scholar in 2024. Her research focuses on Intersectionality in the life writings of non-white American Women Celebrities. Her academic interests lie at the intersection of life writing, migration studies, postcolonial identity, and celebrity studies. Outside of her research, she enjoys travelling and gardening.

Roundtable 2 - The American Gothic, Weird Fiction, and Bodily Horror

This roundtable features Dr. Jimmy Packham (he/him), Dr. Jade Jenkinson (she/her), and Dr. Juha Virtanen (he/him).

Jimmy Packham is a Senior Lecturer in North American Literature at the University of Birmingham, with research specialisms in the Gothic (British and US) and the blue humanities. His first book, *Gothic Utterance* (2021, UWP), explored the role of haunted and revenant voices – and their ethical imperatives – in the nineteenth-century US Gothic tradition. He has recently completed two books: *The Seabed: A Human and Literary History*, co-authored with Laurence Publicover (Bristol) (forthcoming from U Chicago P) and *Coastal Gothic, 1719–2020*, for Cambridge UP's Elements in the Gothic series. He is the co-convenor of the Haunted Shores research network.

Jade Jenkinson completed her PhD in 2024 and has since contributed a chapter to the forthcoming volume *Global Indigenous Horror* (2025). She is currently adapting her thesis into a monograph and preparing articles for journals including *Literature, Critique and Empire Today* and *Comparative American Studies*. She works for a doctoral training partnership supporting PhD students with training and placements, serves on the Code of Conduct Board for the British Association of American Studies, and is a copyeditor for the University of Wales Press’s Gothic series.

Juha Virtanen's previous publications include *Poetry and Performance During the British Poetry Revival 1960-1980: Event and Effect*, as well as the poetry books *Back Channel Apraxia, -LAND*, and *DOOM ENGINES*. He has written academic articles on various topics ranging from the possibility of radical politics in comic book supervillains to hostile environments and Necropolitics in contemporary poetry, and he has most recently been thinking about vertigo and sinking in the work of Jeff VanderMeer. His current longer-term research project focuses on a complex spectrum of "apocalyptic feelings", which he explores – in part – through speculative writing, ecology, and autoethnographic methodologies; in addition, his current creative practice centres on the idea of wrecks and wreckage. He is Senior Lecturer in Contemporary Literature at the University of Kent, and currently lives along the coast in Thanet.

Poster Presentations

We are proud to host four poster presentations at the in-person day of the conference. These research posters were created by Evripidis Karavasilis (he/him), Lolly Sillitoe (she/her), Catarina Moura (she/her), and Eleni Ermiono Tasioula (she/her).

Evripidis' poster is titled 'The American Dream/American Nightmare of Immigration and Nationhood'.

Lolly's poster is titled 'Ecohorror and the Works of Annie Proulx: Imagining Nonhuman Trauma Victims'.

Catarina's poster is titled 'Enduring Myths and Aspirations: The "Last Frontier" in Kristin Hannah's *The Great Alone*'.

Eleni's poster is titled 'Demythologizing California: Reading LA's Systemic Violence in Luis J. Rodriguez's Memoir *Always Running*'.

Panel 1 - Two-Spirit, Trans, and Drag Potentialities in the North American Context

This panel features presentations from Albert William McLeod (Fabulous Animate Being/FAB), Izzy Hardin (they/them), and Lea Pešec (she/her).

Albert's presentation is titled 'Northern American 2Spirit Re-emergence in the 21st Century'.

Izzy's presentation is titled 'Trans Potentiality and State Mobilisation of Historical Figures'.

Lea's presentation is titled 'What Happens When the American Body Goes Drag?'.

Keynote Panel - Speaking to the American Dream / American Nightmare in 2025

The conference's keynote panel consists of Dr. Elsa Devienne (she/her), Dr. Jonathan Ward (he/him), Dr. Christopher Lloyd (he/him), and Dr. Mike Collins (he/him).

Elsa Devienne is Assistant Professor of History and American Studies at Northumbria University. Her first book, *Sand Rush: The Revival of the Beach in Twentieth-Century Los Angeles* (Oxford UP, 2024) won the Willi Paul Adams Award awarded by the Organization of American Historians. She is currently working on two projects: the first is on the history of mobilisations against plastics in the US; and the second, on car dominance and mobility justice, is inspired by her daily struggles cycling and walking in Manchester, where she lives with her partner and two sons. As a member of the executive board of the British Association of American Studies since 2020 and co-lead for GREEN BAAS, its environmental and sustainability network, she has led on a number of initiatives to centre environmental justice in the field at large.

Jonathan Ward is a Lecturer in Race and Diversity Studies at King's College London, in the Department of Culture, Media & Creative Industries. His research is generally interested in somatic disciplinarity and representations of the body in visual, literary, and popular culture. He is currently working on a monograph entitled *"What Is It?": Examining the Construction of the Black Male Body as Threat in American Visual Culture*. His recent work examines "misremembrance" of racialized histories and coloniality in popular culture, the figure of the "White Saviour" in US popular film, the representation of Meghan Markle on Instagram, and the relationship of colonialism to Ryan Coogler's *Black Panther*. He is the founder of The Abolitionist Curriculum.

Christopher Lloyd is an Associate Professor of Learning and Teaching at the University of Hertfordshire. He is the author of two books on contemporary culture from the US South, two edited collections on pedagogy and millennial fiction, and a forthcoming book on queerness and the nonhuman. He is the

host of the Books Up Close podcast and YouTube channel, and the Vice-Chair of the British Association for American Studies.

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